



very earliest, preagricultural societies. The San, like the Pygmy peoples of central Africa, are hunter-gatherers who live in family groups of 10-30 people. The members of the group live as equals and share everything.



Hunting and trapping

Although the San do much of their hunting with a bow and arrow, they also set traps like this one, which is designed to catch a guinea fowl. San men and women are extremely skilled at this and their traps very rarely fail to catch birds or small animals. The animals most commonly hunted are antelope, wildebeest, gemsbok, giraffe, reptiles, and birds.

They are very skilled at hunting animals, and at finding food and water in the bush. They keep only minimal possessions so that they can move easily to a new site if their water source dries up.

PREPARING FOR THE HUNT

Because there are few animals in the bush, hunting is a skilled task and something of a ritual event, reinforcing the relationship between the men in the group.



1 Finding poison

A hunter digs for beetle larvae. They contain a poison which, when it enters an animal's bloodstream, can kill it. One arrow may require the poison of 10 larvae.



2 The mixing bowl

He extracts the poison and mixes it with plant juice and saliva in one of the ball sockets of an eland. The juice acts like glue, making the poison stick to the arrow.



3 Delicate work

The poison is placed on the arrow shaft, not the tip. This is to prevent the hunter from getting poisoned if he accidentally scratches himself with one of his arrows.

PATIENCE AND SKILL

The small poisoned arrows do not inflict much damage on a big animal. The hunter will have to follow the animal's tracks for four or five days until it succumbs to the poison.

